Renewing an expired VPN certificate

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Summary

This article explains how to renew an expired Palo Alto GlobalProtect VPN certificate on Acme Global managed laptops. It provides symptoms, common causes, a user-self-help procedure, verification steps, and the formal service-desk workflow for Network Support.

Symptoms

- VPN connection fails with error "Authentication failed: certificate expired"
- GlobalProtect client shows "Certificate validation failed"
- VPN connects but internal sites (intranet.acme.example, file shares) are unreachable
- Frequent disconnections after a few minutes of use
- Popup notification: "Your VPN certificate has expired; please contact IT"

Common causes

- The GlobalProtect client certificate reached its 1-year validity and expired
- Outdated GlobalProtect client version that does not automatically renew the certificate
- Corrupted or missing certificate in the local store
- Network policies blocking TCP/443 (SSL) traffic to vpn.acme.example
- User-initiated deletion of the certificate from the client

Overview

Acme Global uses Palo Alto GlobalProtect for remote access. The VPN client relies on a machine certificate that is valid for one year. When the certificate expires, the client cannot establish a trusted TLS tunnel, resulting in authentication failures or frequent drops. Renewing the certificate restores secure connectivity without needing to reinstall the client.

Prerequisites

Before attempting renewal, ensure you have an active internet connection (any network will do). You must be logged into the laptop with your domain account and have the GlobalProtect client installed from the Company Portal. No administrative privileges are required for the renewal itself, but you need permission to run the GlobalProtect UI and to install client updates if needed.

Self-Help: Renew VPN Certificate (User)

Follow these steps to renew the certificate yourself. If any step fails, note the exact error message and contact the IT Service Desk.

1. Ensure you are connected to the internet (home Wi-Fi, mobile hotspot, or any other network).
2. Locate the GlobalProtect icon in the system tray (Windows) or menu bar (macOS) and open the client.
3. Click the gear icon -> Settings -> Certificates.
4. If a "Renew Certificate" button is available, click it and follow the prompts.
5. If the Renew option is greyed out or missing, open the Company Portal, check for updates to the GlobalProtect client, and install the latest version.
6. After the update completes, repeat steps 2-4 to attempt renewal again.
7. Once the certificate is renewed, try to connect to vpn.acme.example.
8. Verify connectivity by opening an internal site such as intranet.acme.example or accessing a file share. If successful, the VPN is working.

Verification

After completing the self-help steps, confirm that the VPN is functioning correctly. Check the GlobalProtect client status bar for "Connected" and note the new certificate expiry date under Settings -> Certificates. Perform a quick test: ping an internal server (e.g., fileserver.acme.example) or browse to a SharePoint site. If the connection stays stable for at least

five minutes and internal resources are reachable, the renewal succeeded.

Service Desk Procedure (Agent)

Agents follow this workflow when a user reports an expired VPN certificate. Collect diagnostic information, guide the user through renewal, and, if needed, push a fresh certificate via Intune or issue a Temporary Access Pass.

1. Create a ticket in the Network Support queue and categorize it as "VPN - Certificate Renewal".
2. Ask the user to provide: full name, employee ID, laptop asset tag, operating system version, and a screenshot of the GlobalProtect certificate tab showing the expiry date or error message.
3. Instruct the user to perform the self-help renewal steps outlined above while you stay on the call or monitor the ticket.
4. If the user cannot renew the certificate (e.g., Renew button missing after update), remotely initiate a certificate re-enrollment via Intune: navigate to the device configuration profile for GlobalProtect, select "Renew" or "Re-assign" the certificate profile, and sync the device.
5. After the certificate is pushed, ask the user to reconnect and verify access to internal resources.
6. Close the ticket with resolution "VPN certificate renewed - user connected successfully" and include the final certificate expiry date in the resolution notes.

Additional Tips

To avoid future expirations, ensure the GlobalProtect client is set to auto-update. Administrators can configure Intune to deploy the latest client version monthly. Users should also periodically check the certificate expiry date (Settings -> Certificates) and contact the Network Support team if the expiry is within 30 days. Remember that the VPN uses certificate-based authentication; if the machine certificate is corrupted, a full re-enrollment may be required, which the Network Support team can perform.

When to escalate

If the user cannot renew the certificate after trying the self-help steps and the service-desk agent has verified that the latest GlobalProtect client is installed, escalate to the Network Support team's senior engineer. Include in the escalation: user name, employee ID, device asset tag, OS version, GlobalProtect version, screenshots of the certificate tab showing the error, Intune device sync logs, and any error codes from the client (e.g., 13001 - Certificate validation failed). The senior engineer can force a certificate re-enrollment or issue a Temporary Access Pass via IAM while investigating underlying PKI or Intune policy issues.

Keywords: VPN, certificate, GlobalProtect, renew, expired, authentication failed, connection issue, Palo Alto, network connectivity, Intune, Temporary Access Pass, certificate renewal